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The Birth of a Nation: Influences of American Democracy

On July 4, 1776, the Founding Fathers put a document to the beginning of a brand-new nation: The Declaration of Independence. This document encapsulated the brilliant hopes and dreams of a brand-new America. However, many questions came along with establishing a new nation: How would all Americans be represented in government? How could America be strong and unified without violating the rights of individuals? To answer these questions, the Founding Fathers looked to multiple sources of inspiration. As a result, the development of U.S. democracy was influenced by English documents, the Roman Republic, and the Iroquois Confederacy.

One major influence of U.S. democracy was English documents such as the Magna Carta and English Bill of Rights. Both of these documents set out to protect the rights of individuals in a time where the monarchy had absolute power. In 1215, King John was forced by noblemen to sign the Magna Carta, a document that limited the monarch's power. From the Magna Carta, nobles also secured many undeniable rights, such as the right to a due process of law. This meant that they would have access to a fair trial before being given a punishment. Centuries later in 1689, the English Parliament passed the English Bill of Rights. Signed by the monarchs William and Mary, the English Bill of Rights went a step further in protecting the rights of citizens from

the government, including the right to petition, the right to bear arms, and freedom from cruel and unusual punishment. These documents played a major role in establishing the idea that the government should not be all-powerful and cannot violate certain individual rights of citizens. The influences of these two documents can still be seen in the U.S. Bill of Rights. The first ten amendments of the Constitution protect the inviolable rights of American citizens, such as freedom of speech, the right to bear arms, and the right of trial by jury. It is universally agreed that English documents like the Magna Carta and the English Bill of Rights were major proponents in inspiring the ideas of limited government and individual rights in the U.S. government.

U.S. democracy was also deeply inspired by Ancient Rome. The Roman Republic was a huge nation stretching from Britain to Egypt, with people of different cultures, opinions, and political interests. To make fair decisions representative of all of its citizens, Ancient Rome adopted a representative democracy. The Roman Senate consisted of 300 senators who each represented one province within the empire. Although citizens didn't directly vote on decisions themselves, they were able to vote on a representative who voted on their behalf. This type of government works when a nation is too large for all the citizens to directly vote on issues, like the United States. The Roman idea of representative democracy is reflected in the United States when citizens of each state elect their own representatives to represent their opinions in Congress. This way, the voices of all the people can still be heard in government, while still ensuring efficiency. Representative democracy is still a fundamental part of the government system in America today.

Furthermore, U.S. democracy borrowed many ideas from the Iroquois Confederacy. This was an alliance between the Native American tribes Mohawk, Oneida, Onondaga, Cayuga, and

Seneca in present-day State of New York. While each tribe would settle matters pertaining to itself, the Iroquois Confederacy met together at the Grand Council to jointly make decisions that would affect all the tribes, such as foreign trade policies, foreign diplomatic policies, and inter-tribe conflicts. This is an example of federalism, a government system in which there is a central federal government ruling over smaller state governments. In the United States, the federal government has the ability to declare war, regulate currency, and conduct foreign affairs. On the other hand, state governments in the United States have the power to conduct elections, oversee education, and issue licenses. The struggle between federal and state governments was a hotly debated topic at the founding of our nation. Some Americans felt the need for a strong, united government, while others were reluctant in having the central government become too powerful. The balance of power between federal and state governments is important because it achieves a middle ground in between these two beliefs. In summary, the Iroquois Confederacy inspired the concept of federalism within the United States.

English, Roman, and Iroquois influences are all very much evident in the modern United States. The Magna Carta and the English Bill of Rights established the ideas of limited government and individual rights. Ancient Rome created a model for representation within decision making. The Iroquois Confederacy instilled the idea of federalism. As it approaches its 250th birthday, the United States has gone on to inspire many other governments. To this day, the hopes of the Founding Fathers still live on, guiding us step by step as we move forward as a nation.